

Lead-generation strategy for sourcing surplus chairs from large venues

Problem statement

You need to build an **outreach pipeline** that finds venues with large numbers of chairs (e.g., convention centres, hotels with ballrooms, conference/event centres and churches). Once you can locate venues that have thousands of chairs, you intend to buy surplus chairs at a good price and resell them. The immediate goal is to reach **1000 people**—at least **50 decision-makers** who control events or facility management—and to validate whether this market is viable.

This document outlines **fast lead-capture methods** and an MVP workflow that you can immediately test. It focuses on leveraging open data such as **OpenStreetMap (OSM)** and API-based services like **Google Places API** to identify target venues. It also covers how to enrich those leads and manage outreach using AI tools and a CRM.

Why focus on convention centres and similar venues?

OpenStreetMap defines a *conference centre* (convention centre) as **a large building used to hold a convention** where people gather to promote common interests ¹. Such venues often have huge floor areas that can accommodate several thousand attendees and may be part of a hotel ¹. Convention centres typically include auditoriums, concert halls and meeting rooms ¹, which means they own *thousands of chairs*. Large hotels with ballrooms, community or events centres and megachurches can have similar inventories. These venues are therefore ideal targets for buying surplus chairs.

Data sources and search methods

1. OpenStreetMap + Overpass API

OpenStreetMap (OSM) maintains an open geographic database of points of interest (POIs). The **Overpass API** lets you query OSM data using a flexible query language. A key feature is the `around` operator, which selects all objects within a given radius of a coordinate ². For example, the query below (written in Overpass QL) retrieves all nodes, ways and relations tagged as `amenity=conference_centre` within 50 km of San Diego (32.7157, -117.1611):

```
[out:json][timeout:25];
(
  node["amenity"="conference_centre"](around:50000,32.7157,-117.1611);
  way["amenity"="conference_centre"](around:50000,32.7157,-117.1611);
  relation["amenity"="conference_centre"](around:50000,32.7157,-117.1611);
)
```

```
);  
out body;  
>;  
out skel qt;
```

When run on overpass-turbo.eu, this query returns a JSON list of conference centres within the specified radius, including their names, coordinates and tags like `phone`, `website` and `addr:*` if they exist. You can modify the query to search for other venues:

- **Hotels with ballrooms or meeting spaces** – search for `tourism=hotel` combined with tags such as `meeting_room=yes` or `conference=yes`.
- **Community or events centres** – use `amenity=events_venue`, `amenity=community_centre` or `amenity=exhibition_centre`.
- **Places of worship (churches)** – use `amenity=place_of_worship` and filter by size (e.g., churches with large seating capacity, though capacity is not always mapped).

Because the Overpass API is public, always **respect rate limits** and export moderate batches of results (e.g., per city or 50 km radius). Use the `timeout` parameter to avoid long queries. If you need multiple regions (e.g., Los Angeles, Phoenix), run separate queries.

Extracting contact information

OSM data often includes tags like `phone` and `website` ³. However, many objects lack contact information. To enrich the data:

1. **Export the Overpass results** to a spreadsheet or CSV from overpass-turbo (via *Export* → *download/csv/gejson*).
2. For each venue, automatically fetch the domain from the `website` tag and use an email finder (e.g., Hunter.io, Apollo) to locate role-based emails (e.g., sales@, events@). If the `phone` tag is present, you can call directly.
3. Use enrichment APIs (Clearbit, FullContact) to append company size, industry and verified email addresses.

2. Google Places API (Nearby Search)

Google's **Places API (New)** offers a *Nearby Search* endpoint that lets you search for places based on location and type ⁴. You can specify the search area, place types (e.g., `conference_center`, `church`, `hotel`), language and maximum number of results ⁴. The API uses a **field mask**, which means you decide exactly which data fields to return (e.g., display name, formatted address, website, phone number). Without a field mask, the API returns an error ⁵.

Example POST request (replace with your API key) to find 20 conference centres within a 25-mile (40 km) radius of San Diego and return their display names and formatted addresses:

```
curl -X POST -H 'Content-Type: application/json' \  
      -H 'X-Goog-API-Key: YOUR_API_KEY' \  
      -d '{  
        "location": "San Diego, CA",  
        "radius": 40000,  
        "types": "conference_center",  
        "maxResults": 20,  
        "fields": "name,formatted_address",  
        "key": "YOUR_API_KEY"  
      }'
```

```

-H 'X-Goog-FieldMask:
places.displayName,places.formattedAddress,places.phoneNumber,places.websiteUri,places.types'
\
-d '{
  "includedTypes": ["conference_center"],
  "maxResultCount": 20,
  "locationRestriction": {
    "circle": {
      "center": {"latitude": 32.7157, "longitude": -117.1611},
      "radius": 40000.0
    }
  }
}' \
https://places.googleapis.com/v1/places:searchNearby

```

The response will contain a list of places that match the criteria. Using the API requires a **Google Cloud project with billing enabled**, and specific fields can trigger different pricing tiers ⁶. To keep costs low, request only the fields you need (e.g., `displayName`, `formattedAddress`, `phoneNumber`, `websiteUri`).

3. Other POI services

If you prefer a free alternative to Google's paid API, consider:

- **Geoapify Places API** – offers 3000 free requests/day and supports search by category (e.g., *accommodation*, *tourism*). Each result includes name, address, website and phone number.
- **OpenCage Geocoder** – provides reverse geocoding and location search, which can help verify addresses from Overpass queries.
- **Wikipedia** – lists major convention centres by state; for example, the U.S. page shows the Anaheim Convention Center and others ⁷. These lists are good for manual seeding.

Building an MVP for lead generation

The goal is to quickly test whether venues are willing to sell or dispose of large quantities of chairs. Below is a proposed **minimum viable process (MVP)**:

1. **Define your target radius** – start with your local market (e.g., 100 mile radius around San Diego) so that transport costs remain manageable.
2. **Run Overpass queries** – on `overpass-turbo.eu`, query for `amenity=conference_centre`, `tourism=hotel` and `amenity=events_venue` within your radius. Export the results to CSV. For each venue, record name, coordinates, address, website and phone (if available).
3. **Use a second data source** – run a Google Places Nearby Search or Geoapify Places query for the same radius and categories. This helps capture venues that may not be fully mapped in OSM.

4. **Merge and deduplicate** – combine the two datasets, deduplicate by name/address and prioritise venues that appear in both sources (higher confidence).
5. **Enrich contact information** –
 6. Use the `website` field to derive email domains.
 7. Use email-discovery tools (Hunter, Apollo) to find event management or facility management contacts.
 8. Where email is not available, call the phone number from the dataset or search the venue’s website manually.
9. **Prioritise high-capacity venues** – as you review results, flag venues with the largest seating capacities. Publicly available capacity data (e.g., San Diego Convention Center has 47,840 theatre seats ⁸) can help you focus on venues with thousands of chairs.
10. **Import leads into a CRM** – use a CRM like Apollo, HubSpot or Zoho. Create custom fields for venue type, capacity estimate, decision-maker contact and status. Upload your enriched CSV.
11. **Craft outreach messages** – use an AI assistant (e.g., Anthropic Claude or ChatGPT) to generate personalised outreach emails. Provide the tool with a prompt template (e.g., highlight that you buy surplus chairs and offer to clear excess inventory quickly). Test different message variants.
12. **Test multiple channels** – assign “agents” to try different outreach methods: phone calls, personalised emails, LinkedIn messages. Track response rates and refine the approach.
13. **Iterate** – after the first 50 contacts, analyse which venues responded positively, which message variants worked best, and whether the targeted capacity threshold is appropriate. Adjust your queries or filters and repeat.

Prompt ideas for AI-assisted lead discovery

When using a platform like Apollo or a custom AI assistant to find leads, you can feed it prompts that reflect the categories you want to search. Examples:

Use-case	Example prompt snippet (to input into Apollo’s AI search)
Find convention centres	Find companies or facilities tagged as conference, convention or exhibition centres within 200 miles of San Diego, California. Include venues with seating capacities $\geq 5,000$ and return the events/operations manager’s contact details.

Use-case	Example prompt snippet (to input into Apollo's AI search)
Identify hotels with large ballrooms	Search for hotels or resorts in Southern California that market themselves as event venues, ballrooms or meeting centres. Include those with multiple ballrooms or large banquet halls and return the contact details of their events coordinator.
Locate megachurches or large places of worship	Identify churches or religious venues in California with auditoriums or sanctuaries seating 1,500+ people. Provide the facility manager's contact information if available.
General surplus assets	Find organisations that hold large events and might have surplus seating or event equipment for sale, such as stadiums, arenas, convention centres, or large hotels. Return the operations or procurement manager's email.

These prompts can be refined over time. Start broad to build a large lead list, then filter for capacity or ownership (private vs. government). Combine them with your own manual research on specific venues.

Next steps and refinement

- **Run a small pilot:** Focus on one metropolitan area and contact 20–50 venues. Analyse responses to understand whether venues are willing to sell chairs and at what price. Document obstacles (e.g., existing contracts with suppliers, storage issues). Use this feedback to refine the business hypothesis.
- **Automate data collection:** Once the pilot is validated, write a script (Python with `requests` and `pandas`) to call Overpass and (if available) the Google Places API. Use the script to refresh the venue list periodically (e.g., monthly) and automatically update your CRM via its API.
- **Scale geographically:** After refining your search prompts and message templates, expand the radius to neighbouring states. Consider logistic costs when evaluating leads.
- **Stay within data-use policies:** Respect OSM's data licence (Open Database Licence) and Google's API terms. Avoid high-volume scraping that might violate service policies. Use commercial services (Apollo, Clearbit) under their licensing terms.

By following this structured process—combining open geodata with API-powered search and enrichment—you can rapidly compile a list of potential sellers, engage them through multiple channels and validate whether bulk chair acquisition is a feasible business. The same workflow can be adapted for other surplus event equipment.

¹ ³ Tag:amenity=conference_centre - OpenStreetMap Wiki

https://wiki.openstreetmap.org/wiki/Tag:amenity=conference_centre

2 Overpass API - OpenStreetMap Wiki

https://wiki.openstreetmap.org/wiki/Overpass_API

4 5 6 Nearby Search (New) | Places API | Google for Developers

<https://developers.google.com/maps/documentation/places/web-service/nearby-search>

7 List of convention centers in the United States - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_convention_centers_in_the_United_States

8 San Diego Convention Center - San Diego, CA Convention Center & Event Space | Meetings & Conventions

<https://www.meetings-conventions.com/Meeting-Event-Venues/San-Diego/Convention-Center/San-Diego-Convention-Center-p2232773>